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From the editor-in-chief

Even before a single ball has been bowled, the Indian Premier League's second edition has already produced drama, suspense, colour, conflict and excitement. The fate of IPL-2 sparked heated television and drawing room debates, often raising the bizarre question over which was more important, a commercial cricket tournament or the general elections. BJP leaders launching a scathing attack on the ruling party over the event being outsourced was an indication that it had become a prickly election issue. Shorn of the political scoring shots, it was another reminder that cricket and politics can never be separated. With so many Bollywood stars involved in the IPL, the triumvirate that rules the Indian mindspace was complete.

Eventually, the security issue and the dates clashing with polling in some states led to the organisers deciding to shift the tournament to South Africa, but the move raises quite a few questions. The first is the choice of an overseas venue. The stalemate between the BCCI and Home Ministry could have been somehow resolved but clearly IPL Commissioner Lalit Modi and Home Minister P. Chidambaram were a case of irresistible force and immovable object. Hosting a high-profile tournament like the IPL with its city/state linkages and the energy, excitement and crowd support in India can obviously not be matched anywhere else. Being a purely commercial venture, revenue loss raises the biggest question. The IPL is based on a revenue-sharing model between the BCCI, IPL and franchisees who have already paid out \$7.6 million to hire new players. IPL-2 was estimated to generate around Rs 700 crore through broadcasting rights, ground sponsorships, ticket sales and sponsorships. Broadcasters say that TV viewership will be 15 per cent lower because of the change in venue. The IPL will also have to pay Cricket South Africa a fee while Indian advertisers and sponsors are doing a rethink since their main audience was local. Gate receipts (estimated at Rs 5 crore) will also be affected and there will be a drop in revenue from in-stadia events, product launches and other promotions.

Besides all this there is the logistical nightmare it poses for team owners by way of accommodation, air tickets and visas for 400-plus people; players, officials, umpires, team owners and their support staff, coming from various countries and located in six different cities for a period of 37 days. In India, hotel chains were hospitality partners which will not be the case in South Africa. The BCCI has already paid out \$10 million to compensate franchisees and has pledged to pay an additional \$10 million, money it can well afford. The BCCI is the superpower in world cricket because of its financial clout and the estimated Rs 1,800 crore it has in reserves.

However, lacking local fans, taking place thousands of miles away and marketed as a television spectacle, sport becomes soulless. The Indian Premier League was a huge success. The International Premier League is nothing short of a Great Gamble. Hopefully, the gamble will pay off and Indian cricket fans will not be disappointed.

Aroon Purie

(Aroon Purie)



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